

Mr. Hollander turned out to be helpful and especially well informed. He told me that his father, Oscar, had traded in the corn pits as early as 1919. My Mr. Hollander had been trading since he left the Air Force in the mid-1940s. He also had a son in the business, which made three generations of Hollanders in corn.

I asked Mr. Hollander what it was like in the old days of physical corn. "The boxcars came into Chicago to a central inspection point at the railroad yard," he said. "The state would inspect the shipment. There'd be a sample of corn taken from each car and put into a paper bag. The paper bags were brought to the trading floor at the Chicago Board of Trade and put up on the flat marble desks, one desk for each separate carload. After the corn was bought and sold, we'd take the bills of lading and send the trains on to their final destinations."

Today, Mr. Hollander continued, the corn never reached Chicago. Instead it was inspected at the point of origin and the orders were placed by telephone. Corn was a form of settlement. A single bushel might be hedged and speculated 25 times in its theoretical life. I asked if there were futures traders who'd never seen an actual carload of corn, and Mr. Hollander supposed there were.

As to my investment, Mr. Hollander agreed with Mr. Silverstein. He, too, was optimistic about this year's harvest, which made him bearish on the futures. "Don't be long," he said. "Be short. Short the September 170 contract." I carefully wrote this down.

After I left Mr. Hollander, I heard about another family, the Schneiders, with four generations in futures. The great-great grandfather, Sam, sold eggs, while the latest Schneiders traded gold, T-Bills, and Eurodollars. Mr. Epstein told me that several Chicago families had followed the same evolution from the cash market to the futures, from edibles to currencies, from the pits to the computers. The skill of trading hadn't changed, and Mr. Epstein suggested it may even have been inbred.

I narrowed my investment choices to the Japanese yen long, the corn short, the deutsche mark spread, and the live-hog option. After going over it back and forth for another half hour with Mr. Epstein, he suggested that for my \$2,000 I could pick up a small contract on each. He also arranged for me to follow my own buy and sell orders down through the pits. This would have been im-